



THE SKOAR

8

MASS EFFECT 2

Developer: BioWare

Publisher: Electronic Arts

Genre: RPG, Third person shooter

Platforms: PC, Xbox 360 (Rs. 999, PC)

fixes. The plotline lacks the steady development like it did in the first game. The upside is that *Mass Effect 2* has a much more dramatic climax with multiple possible outcomes. The sequel has inherited engaging the storytelling from the first game, all thanks to robust voice acting, a decent script, use of dynamic camera and interactive cut scenes. Even though narration in *Mass Effect 2* is an improvement over the first game, there is still plenty of room for improvement. Visually, this game is much richer than its predecessor due to improved texture and lighting, and this further enhances the story presentation.

Differences

There are a couple of major changes in the combat system, like use of ammo system instead of weapon-heating and introduction of auto-healing, which means that the most common use of medi-gel (healing item) is to revive fallen party members. *Mass Effect 2* has also completely done away with weapon proficiencies, grenades and mines. A significant addition to the weapon's system is heavy weaponry that can be very effective at turning the tide of battle. Unfortunately, the cover system is still inconsistent and AI controlled party members continue to suck at finding cover.

When you think about some of the changes in the game system, you begin to see a pattern. Most of the major gripes that players had with *Mass Effect* have not been improved on, but

rather they have been completely eliminated. The suspiciously long elevator rides have been replaced by a loading screen; Mako (the planetfall vehicle from the first part) does not make an appearance in ME2 and it has no replacement. The cumbersome inventory screen has also been completely eliminated and instead missions start with a load-out screen, mostly limiting your choice of arsenal on a mission. We completed about five planetary exploration missions and none of those had anything to write home about. ME2 has taken a different approach to resource gathering. Activating a planet on the Galaxy Map brings up a 3D model of the planet, which can be used to scan the surface for valuable metals. This is essentially a mini-game that uses Left-Trigger to initiate scanning and right trigger to send a probe to collect the resources. We found this to be a tedious exercise; so between the two games, we're not sure which system is better.

Building your team

Gathering of resources is not something that can be completely ignored as the game requires huge quantities of metals for upgrade research. And even though upgrades are not necessary for combat, having them has a significant impact on the game's ending. Due to this, upgrades in *Mass Effect 2* are not easy to come by and they require a lot of credits and metals. After you have successfully gathered most of your team

and gained their loyalty, the game really starts to get interesting. Unfortunately, by this time you are nearing the end of the game and the best is saved only for the last few hours. After finishing the main quest, the game continues and gives you the opportunity for exploration of completing side-missions. Alternately, you can start a New Game+ with additional bonuses. From the main menu of the game you can access the Cerberus Network, which is a fancy name for EA's DLC distribution system. This requires a redeem code to unlock (or a toll of 1200 MS Points) and since we did not receive a code with the review copy, we really could not explore the system. This was kind of depressing because we could not download the free day-one DLC or the Blood Dragon armor from *Dragon Age Origins*.

The verdict

Just like the first game, *Mass Effect 2* is not particularly impressive; however it's not a bad game either. With the sequel you will find more of the same with a coat of polish - a trademark EA release. As mentioned earlier, many of the issues from the first game have not been effectively addressed in the sequel. So if you enjoyed the first game, there is a good chance that you will feel the same way about *Mass Effect 2*. As long as you are not expecting anything revolutionary or radically different, you should find ME2 a worthwhile experience.